



Induja Kumar '24

Law, History, and Society - Data Science

As I mentioned in my application for the Nichols grant, for most of my childhood my energy was focused on excellence in all the things I did, including in the arts. I did dance for most of my adolescence, and we were constricted to sets of rules in which we were to move our bodies in accordance with the way the art form was structured. I did not get to experiment with it until I was much older and graduated from beginning levels of learning. Since going to college, I've abandoned the arts altogether; it seems I can never find time for them.

My time with Rising Youth Theatre was, therefore, a break from what I was used to. Rising Youth Theatre focuses on helping children, especially from underserved communities find creativity in the arts. One of the biggest things I noticed that they do very differently from other nonprofits in the Arts Education field, is that their work is intergenerational: kids, adults, and teenagers all in the same room, and children who grew up in the program often become "apprentices" in the program in high school or college. This long-term vision is one of the many reasons I appreciated RYT's commitment to bringing arts and arts education to the valley.

Arizona has long lacked the endowment for the arts that many other states have, which I had learned through a year of volunteering with the Chandler Arts Center during my senior year. During the pandemic, the number of students who have access to arts resources has only been lowered. Being in a (virtual) room full of kids who have been doing school on zoom for over a year and devising creative ways for them to engage with the arts (visual arts, dance, and drama together) has nonetheless proven to me how valuable the arts are, especially for young children to learn how to express their feelings and process emotions, create something and feel that they are a part of something bigger than themselves (which is so much more important during

Kumar worked with an art education nonprofit to focus on helping children, especially from underserved communities find creativity in the arts.

our current state of isolation), and build community.

As an apprentice, I was so surprised by the adults I worked with; they treated kids as their equals in intellect and ability, they were ever so resourceful, both in coming up with exercises for students to do at home and in helping guide students towards ideas for the final showcase, which we managed to put on even in a virtual setting, incorporating ideas from all the students. Most importantly students' creativity was never taken for granted. One of our rules is "don't yuck someone's yum" — that is, don't put down what someone else finds enjoyable. This rule encompasses a lot of what went on during our camp; students were given full freedom to express every part of themselves, and in the process were able to create something that played with the bounds of reality: writing stories about a sardine who is shunned by his family for wanting to be a painter, or a girl who hates bats but later turns into one, and realizes how important they are to a desert environment like Arizona, and through the process, were able to recognize that change is a part of life (which they were only too familiar with), and that sometimes those changes bring hardships, but they may also help you find a hidden part of you that is strong and willing to take on anything, that was there all along.



One of our rules is "don't yuck someone's yum" —that is, don't put down what someone else finds enjoyable.